

Question ID: 0acc26b2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Hard

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Astronomers estimate that the number of comets orbiting the Sun is in the billions.
- 81P/Wild is one of many comets whose orbit has changed over time.
- 81P/Wild’s orbit once lay between the orbits of Uranus and Jupiter.
- The comet’s orbit is now positioned between the orbits of Jupiter and Mars.

The student wants to make and support a generalization about the orbits of comets. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish these goals?

Answer

- A. Astronomers estimate that the number of comets orbiting the Sun is in the billions; the comets’ orbits may change over time.
- B. Like Uranus, Jupiter, and Mars, billions of comets orbit the Sun.
- C. One example of a comet is 81P/Wild, whose orbit around the Sun once lay between Uranus’s and Jupiter’s orbits but is now positioned between those of Jupiter and Mars.
- D. A comet’s orbit around the Sun may change over time: the orbit of comet 81P/Wild once lay between the orbits of Uranus and Jupiter but is now positioned between those of Jupiter and Mars.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence makes a generalization—that a comet’s orbit around the Sun may change over time—and supports the generalization with the example of the orbit of comet 81P/Wild, which once lay between the orbits of Uranus and Jupiter but is now positioned between the orbits of Jupiter and Mars.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the number of comets orbiting the Sun and makes a generalization about their orbits, but it doesn’t support the generalization with an example. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence makes a generalization about comets and compares them to the planets Uranus, Jupiter, and Mars; it doesn’t make and support a generalization about comets’ orbits. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence provides an example of a comet whose orbit has changed, it doesn’t make a generalization about the orbits of comets.